LESSON 2

What Is a Christian Herbalist?

Faith • Stewardship • Education • Whole-Person Wellness

Course: NHMEC Biblical Herbalism Foundations
Module: Module 2.1 — Biblical Herbalism
Lesson: Lesson 2
Instructor: Min. Penny Lane Whittemore CNC BCNWP CHGp RHCH CHHWC
Education Center: Natural Health Ministries Education Center
Learning Hub: PENothecary™ Membership Website

Lesson Overview

In Lesson 1, we learned that Biblical Herbalism begins with God as Creator. We learned that herbs are part of God's provision, but they are never to become objects of worship. We also learned that herbal study must be handled with humility, discernment, stewardship, and educational responsibility.

In this lesson, we will answer the question:

What is a Christian herbalist?

A Christian herbalist is not simply someone who studies herbs. A Christian herbalist is someone who studies herbs through a biblical worldview, recognizing God as the ultimate healer and the body as part of God's design. A Christian herbalist approaches herbal education with prayer, compassion, discernment, safety, and a desire to serve others.

A Christian herbalist does not diagnose disease, prescribe treatments, replace medical care, or promise healing. Instead, a Christian herbalist educates, encourages, supports, and guides others in learning how herbs, foods, prayer, scripture, and lifestyle stewardship may support whole-person wellness.

The Christian herbalist must always remember:

God is the healer.
Christ is the center.
The Holy Spirit is the guide.
The Word of God is the foundation.
Herbs are part of creation, not the source of salvation.
Education must remain responsible, safe, and truthful.

Lesson Scripture Foundations

1 Thessalonians 5:23 KJV

“And the very God of peace sanctify you wholly; and I pray God your whole spirit and soul and body be preserved blameless unto the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Colossians 3:17 KJV

“And whatsoever ye do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God and the Father by him.”

Proverbs 11:14 KJV

“Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety.”

James 1:5 KJV

“If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him.”

Galatians 6:2 KJV

“Bear ye one another's burdens, and so fulfil the law of Christ.”

Lesson Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

1. Define what a Christian herbalist is from a biblical and educational perspective.
2. Explain the difference between a Christian herbalist and a medical provider.
3. Understand the role of faith, prayer, scripture, and compassion in Christian herbal education.
4. Identify the spirit, soul, and body as parts of whole-person wellness.
5. Describe the ethical and legal boundaries of Christian herbal work.
6. Explain why safety, humility, and referral are important.
7. Write a personal Christian herbalist statement of purpose.

Opening Teaching

A Christian herbalist is a servant first.

Before herbs, before formulas, before classes, before titles, before certificates, and before ministry work, the Christian herbalist must be rooted in Christ. Herbal knowledge is not the foundation of the Christian herbalist. Jesus Christ is the foundation.

A Christian herbalist studies herbs because God created them. A Christian herbalist teaches because knowledge can help others. A Christian herbalist serves because Christ commanded us to love our neighbor. A Christian herbalist prays because wisdom comes from God. A Christian herbalist uses discernment because not every practice connected to herbs honors the Lord.

The Christian herbalist must understand that people are more than symptoms. People are created by God with a spirit, soul, and body. This is why Christian herbal education cannot only focus on the physical body. It must also recognize emotional burdens, spiritual needs, lifestyle patterns, stress, grief, fear, food habits, rest, and the condition of the heart.

A person may come asking about herbs, but underneath that question may be weariness, confusion, fear, grief, or a desire to be heard. A Christian herbalist should not treat people like projects. A Christian herbalist should treat people with compassion, patience, humility, and care.

The role of the Christian herbalist is not to be the healer.

The role of the Christian herbalist is to point people back to God, teach responsibly, offer safe education, and encourage wise stewardship of the body.

A Christian Herbalist Defined

A Christian herbalist is a person who studies and teaches the use of herbs, foods, and natural resources from a Christian worldview, while honoring God as Creator and ultimate healer.

A Christian herbalist may study:

Herbs
Foods
Seeds
Roots
Flowers
Leaves
Barks
Oils
Spices
Resins
Biblical plants
Traditional preparations
Safety
Stewardship
Prayer
Scripture
Nutrition
Lifestyle habits
Whole-person wellness

However, the Christian herbalist must study these things with clear boundaries.

A Christian herbalist is not a doctor unless they are legally licensed as one.
A Christian herbalist does not diagnose disease.
A Christian herbalist does not prescribe herbs as medical treatment.
A Christian herbalist does not tell people to stop medication.
A Christian herbalist does not promise healing.
A Christian herbalist does not replace emergency care.
A Christian herbalist does not make disease cure claims.

A Christian herbalist may educate, encourage, teach, prepare general wellness resources, discuss traditional uses of herbs, share safety information, and help people think more carefully about stewardship of the body.

The Christian Herbalist as an Educator

Education is one of the safest and most important roles of a Christian herbalist.

A Christian herbalist can teach people how to:

Recognize common kitchen herbs
Understand basic herbal preparations
Study biblical plants
Make simple teas
Prepare herbal oils for general use
Create a wellness journal
Understand basic safety concerns
Read labels
Ask better questions
Pray for wisdom
Care for the body with gratitude
Build nourishing habits
Use herbs responsibly in the home

The educator’s role is to provide information, not medical orders.

There is a difference between saying:

“This herb cures your condition.”

And saying:

“This herb has been traditionally used to support general wellness, but it may not be right for everyone. Please check with your healthcare provider if you are pregnant, nursing, taking medication, or managing a medical condition.”

A Christian herbalist must learn how to speak wisely. Words carry responsibility. What we say can influence decisions. When people are afraid or suffering, they may hold tightly to what we tell them. That is why we must be careful.

A Christian herbalist must be truthful, humble, and cautious.

The Christian Herbalist as a Servant

Jesus taught us to love our neighbor. The Christian herbalist's work should be shaped by compassion, not pride.

People may come to a Christian herbalist because they feel overwhelmed, unheard, tired, discouraged, or confused. Some may be looking for help after trying many things. Some may be searching for natural options. Some may simply want to learn how to care for their family.

The Christian herbalist should not respond with fear, control, judgment, or pressure.

The Christian herbalist should respond with compassion.

A servant-hearted Christian herbalist listens well.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist does not shame people.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist does not use fear to sell products.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist does not pretend to know everything.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist knows when to refer out.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist respects the person's medical care team.
A servant-hearted Christian herbalist prays for wisdom and speaks with grace.

Galatians 6:2 reminds us to bear one another's burdens. This does not mean we carry burdens in our own strength. It means we serve with Christlike compassion while keeping proper boundaries.

Whole-Person Wellness: Spirit, Soul, and Body

A major part of Christian herbalism is the understanding that people are whole beings.

1 Thessalonians 5:23 speaks of spirit, soul, and body. This does not mean every issue is spiritual, and it does not mean every physical problem is caused by sin. It means that human beings are deeply connected and must be cared for with wisdom.

Spirit

The spirit relates to a person's relationship with God, faith, worship, prayer, hope, and spiritual life.

A Christian herbalist may encourage:

Prayer
Scripture reading
Thanksgiving
Faith in God
Repentance where needed
Forgiveness
Worship
Trust in the Lord
Seeking pastoral care when appropriate

The Christian herbalist must never force prayer or scripture on someone in a way that is harsh or manipulative. Prayer should be offered with humility, compassion, and respect.

Soul

The soul includes the mind, emotions, will, thoughts, and inner life.

A person may be carrying:

Fear
Stress
Grief
Anger
Shame
Disappointment
Confusion
Overwhelm
Emotional exhaustion

A Christian herbalist may encourage journaling, rest, prayer, emotional support, wise counsel, pastoral care, and professional mental health support when needed.

A Christian herbalist should not act as a licensed counselor unless they are legally qualified. However, they can listen compassionately, encourage biblical truth, and refer when a person needs deeper support.

Body

The body includes physical health, nourishment, sleep, movement, hydration, digestion, energy, and daily habits.

A Christian herbalist may educate about:

Whole foods
Hydration
Rest
Gentle movement
Herbal teas

Simple kitchen herbs
Traditional preparations
Safety
General wellness habits
Herbal stewardship
Body awareness

A Christian herbalist should encourage people to seek licensed medical care for serious symptoms, emergencies, pregnancy complications, medication questions, infections, severe pain, mental health crises, or chronic disease management.

Whole-person wellness means we do not separate the person into pieces. We care about the whole person while remembering the boundaries of our role.

Prayer and Scripture in Christian Herbalism

Prayer and scripture are important in Christian herbalism because we depend on God for wisdom.

James 1:5 teaches us to ask God for wisdom. This is important because herbal study requires discernment. A student may find many different opinions, traditions, claims, and practices. Prayer helps keep the heart humble and dependent on God.

Prayer may be used:

Before studying
Before teaching
Before preparing herbs
Before meeting with someone
Before making educational recommendations
When asking God for wisdom
When comforting someone
When seeking discernment

Scripture may be used:

For encouragement
For correction
For wisdom
For comfort
For reflection
For teaching biblical stewardship
For reminding students that God is the healer

However, prayer and scripture must never be used to manipulate people. A Christian herbalist should not say, “If you had enough faith, you would be healed.” That is harmful and unbiblical in how it burdens the

suffering person. Many faithful people in Scripture suffered. Jesus showed compassion to the suffering, not shame.

Prayer should point people to God's comfort, not to guilt.

Scripture should bring truth, not condemnation.

The Christian Herbalist and Safety

Safety is a spiritual responsibility as well as an educational responsibility.

It is not enough to say, "It is natural." Natural does not always mean safe. Some herbs may be too strong for certain people. Some herbs may interact with medications. Some herbs may not be appropriate during pregnancy, nursing, childhood, surgery, chronic illness, or certain medical conditions.

A responsible Christian herbalist asks safety questions such as:

Is this person pregnant or nursing?
Is this person taking medication?
Does this person have allergies?
Is this person under medical care?
Is this herb safe for children?
Is this herb safe for elders?
Could this herb interact with medication?
Could this herb be too stimulating, sedating, drying, moistening, heating, or cooling?
Is this a situation that needs medical referral?

A Christian herbalist should not be offended by safety questions. Safety is part of loving our neighbor.

The more we care about people, the more careful we become.

What a Christian Herbalist Does Not Do

A Christian herbalist must understand the difference between ministry, education, coaching, and medical care.

A Christian herbalist does not:

Diagnose disease
Prescribe treatment
Treat illness
Claim to cure disease
Replace a doctor

Discourage emergency care
Tell people to stop medication
Guarantee outcomes
Use fear-based sales tactics
Use occult practices
Practice divination
Use spellwork
Worship plants
Encourage idolatry
Shame people for being sick
Blame every illness on sin
Make claims beyond their training

This protects the student, the client, the ministry, and the witness of Christ.

What a Christian Herbalist May Do

A Christian herbalist may:

Teach general herbal education
Discuss traditional uses of herbs
Share biblical plant studies
Encourage prayer and scripture
Teach basic herbal preparations
Support healthy lifestyle education
Encourage nourishment and rest
Teach herb safety basics
Help students build wellness journals
Create educational handouts
Offer general wellness support
Encourage people to talk with their healthcare provider
Refer out when needed
Serve with compassion
Pray with permission
Point people back to God

The Christian herbalist's work should bring order, peace, wisdom, and encouragement.

The Christian Herbalist's Heart Posture

The heart posture of the Christian herbalist matters.

A person can know many herbs and still lack wisdom.
A person can create many formulas and still lack humility.

A person can teach many classes and still forget compassion.
A person can use scripture and still speak harshly.
A person can say “God created herbs” and still misuse them.

The Christian herbalist must continually examine the heart.

Ask yourself:

Am I serving or trying to be seen?
Am I teaching or trying to control?
Am I helping or trying to prove something?
Am I honoring God or building my own name?
Am I speaking truthfully or exaggerating?
Am I staying in my scope or crossing boundaries?
Am I pointing people to God or to myself?

A Christian herbalist must remain teachable. The Lord can correct us, refine us, and mature us as we grow.

Biblical Example: The Wise Servant

The Christian herbalist should be a wise servant.

A wise servant does not rush.
A wise servant listens.
A wise servant studies.
A wise servant prays.
A wise servant knows when to speak and when to be quiet.
A wise servant knows when to refer.
A wise servant does not pretend to be the healer.
A wise servant gives glory to God.

In herbal education, wisdom is not only knowing what herb to use. Wisdom is knowing when not to suggest an herb. Wisdom is knowing when someone needs a doctor. Wisdom is knowing when someone needs prayer, rest, food, counsel, emergency care, or simply a compassionate ear.

The Christian herbalist must learn that sometimes the most faithful thing to say is:

“This is outside my scope, and I encourage you to contact your healthcare provider.”

That statement is not weakness. That statement is wisdom.

Christian Herbalist Scope Statement

Every Christian herbalist should have a clear scope statement.

A scope statement helps students explain what they do and what they do not do. It protects the student, the public, and the ministry.

Sample Scope Statement

“I am a Christian herbal wellness educator. I provide faith-centered herbal education, biblical plant study, traditional wellness information, and general lifestyle support from a Christian perspective. I do not diagnose, treat, prescribe, cure, or replace medical care. All information shared is for educational purposes only. Individuals should consult a licensed healthcare provider for medical concerns, medications, pregnancy, chronic illness, or emergency symptoms.”

Students may adapt this statement for their own future educational work.

Teacher’s Teaching Notes

When teaching this lesson, emphasize that the Christian herbalist is not defined by a title alone. The Christian herbalist is defined by faith, fruit, humility, safety, compassion, and responsible education.

Students may come into this lesson with different backgrounds. Some may already use herbs. Some may fear herbs because of occult associations. Some may have been harmed by extreme natural health claims. Some may have deep faith but little herbal knowledge. Others may have herbal knowledge but need biblical grounding.

Teach this lesson with balance.

Remind students:

Herbs are not evil.
Herbs are not God.
Herbs are not magic.
Herbs are not a replacement for medical care.
Herbs can be studied responsibly.
Herbs can be used as part of general wellness education.
Christian herbalists must keep Christ first.

Student Reflection

Take time to answer the following questions in your notebook or student workbook.

1. How would you define a Christian herbalist?
2. Why is it important for a Christian herbalist to understand spirit, soul, and body?
3. What is the difference between educating and prescribing?
4. Why should a Christian herbalist avoid making cure claims?
5. How can prayer and scripture support the work of a Christian herbalist?
6. Why is safety part of loving your neighbor?
7. When should a Christian herbalist refer someone to a licensed healthcare provider?
8. What heart posture should a Christian herbalist maintain?

Vocabulary Words

Christian Herbalist: A person who studies and teaches herbs, foods, and natural resources from a Christian worldview while honoring God as Creator and ultimate healer.

Scope of Practice: The boundaries of what a person is trained, legally allowed, and ethically responsible to do.

Educational Role: Teaching and sharing information without diagnosing, prescribing, treating, or replacing medical care.

Whole-Person Wellness: A Christian wellness perspective that considers spirit, soul, and body.

Referral: Directing someone to a licensed professional or emergency care when their need is outside your role.

Discernment: Spirit-led wisdom used to recognize what is true, safe, biblical, and appropriate.

Stewardship: Responsible care of the body, creation, knowledge, words, and ministry.

Lesson 2 Summary

A Christian herbalist is a servant, educator, and steward who studies herbs through a biblical worldview. The Christian herbalist recognizes God as Creator and ultimate healer. Herbs are viewed as part of God's provision, but they are not worshiped, idolized, or treated as magical.

A Christian herbalist supports whole-person wellness by considering spirit, soul, and body. Prayer and scripture may be included with humility and compassion. Herbal education must be handled safely and responsibly.

The Christian herbalist does not diagnose, prescribe, treat disease, make cure claims, replace doctors, or tell people to stop medication. Instead, the Christian herbalist teaches, encourages, supports, studies, prays, refers when needed, and serves others with Christlike compassion.

Remember:

God is the healer.
Christ is the center.
The Holy Spirit gives wisdom.
The Word of God is the foundation.
Herbs are part of creation.
Education must remain responsible.
Compassion must guide the work.

Closing Prayer

Father God,

Thank You for teaching me that service begins with humility. Help me understand what it means to be a Christian herbalist in a way that honors You. Teach me to study carefully, speak truthfully, and serve compassionately.

Help me remember that You are the ultimate healer. Keep me from pride, fear, exaggeration, and error. Give me wisdom to know what is within my role and what must be referred to others. Help me care for the spirit, soul, and body with biblical truth, safety, and love.

Let my herbal studies become an act of stewardship and service, not self-promotion. Let everything I learn bring glory back to You.

In Jesus' name,
Amen.

Instructor Closing

Students, Lesson 2 teaches us that a Christian herbalist is more than a person who knows herbs. A Christian herbalist is a servant of God, a steward of knowledge, and an educator who must walk in wisdom.

Before you learn how to prepare herbs, study formulas, or teach others, you must understand your role. You are not the healer. You are not the doctor. You are not the Savior. You are a student, servant, educator, and steward.

Serve with humility.
Study with diligence.

Speak with care.
Pray for wisdom.
Refer when needed.
Keep Christ at the center.

This is the heart of a Christian herbalist.

Vocabulary Words

Christian Herbalist: A person who studies and teaches herbs, foods, and natural resources from a Christian worldview while honoring God as Creator and ultimate healer.

Scope of Practice: The boundaries of what a person is trained, legally allowed, and ethically responsible to do.

Educational Role: Teaching and sharing information without diagnosing, prescribing, treating, or replacing medical care.

Whole-Person Wellness: A Christian wellness perspective that considers spirit, soul, and body.

Referral: Directing someone to a licensed professional or emergency care when their need is outside your role.

Discernment: Spirit-led wisdom used to recognize what is true, safe, biblical, and appropriate.

Stewardship: Responsible care of the body, creation, knowledge, words, and ministry.

Lesson 2 Summary

A Christian herbalist is a servant, educator, and steward who studies herbs through a biblical worldview. The Christian herbalist recognizes God as Creator and ultimate healer. Herbs are viewed as part of God's provision, but they are not worshiped, idolized, or treated as magical.

A Christian herbalist supports whole-person wellness by considering spirit, soul, and body. Prayer and scripture may be included with humility and compassion. Herbal education must be handled safely and responsibly.

The Christian herbalist does not diagnose, prescribe, treat disease, make cure claims, replace doctors, or tell people to stop medication. Instead, the Christian herbalist teaches, encourages, supports, studies, prays, refers when needed, and serves others with Christlike compassion.

Remember:

God is the healer.
Christ is the center.
The Holy Spirit gives wisdom.
The Word of God is the foundation.
Herbs are part of creation.
Education must remain responsible.
Compassion must guide the work.

Closing Prayer

Father God,

Thank You for teaching me that service begins with humility. Help me understand what it means to be a Christian herbalist in a way that honors You. Teach me to study carefully, speak truthfully, and serve compassionately.

Help me remember that You are the ultimate healer. Keep me from pride, fear, exaggeration, and error. Give me wisdom to know what is within my role and what must be referred to others. Help me care for the spirit, soul, and body with biblical truth, safety, and love.

Let my herbal studies become an act of stewardship and service, not self-promotion. Let everything I learn bring glory back to You.

In Jesus' name,
Amen.

Instructor Closing

Students, Lesson 2 teaches us that a Christian herbalist is more than a person who knows herbs. A Christian herbalist is a servant of God, a steward of knowledge, and an educator who must walk in wisdom.

Before you learn how to prepare herbs, study formulas, or teach others, you must understand your role. You are not the healer. You are not the doctor. You are not the Savior. You are a student, servant, educator, and steward.

Serve with humility.
Study with diligence.
Speak with care.
Pray for wisdom.
Refer when needed.
Keep Christ at the center.

This is the heart of a Christian herbalist.